



SEPTEMBER – THE FINAL PREPARATIONS FOR WINTER

September is the month when beekeepers begin seeing the results of the decisions made throughout the summer.

The excitement of swarm season has passed, supers have largely been removed, and many colonies are now focused on a single objective: surviving the winter ahead.

While there is often still plenty of activity at the hive entrance on warm days, appearances can be misleading. September is not really a summer month for the bees. It is an autumn month.

The colony is no longer trying to expand.

It is trying to survive.

WEATHER, TEMPERATURE & SEASONAL TIMING (SEPTEMBER IN THE UK)

September can be unpredictable.

Some years bring warm sunshine and excellent flying weather, while others deliver prolonged rain and noticeably cooler temperatures. Colonies often continue foraging whenever conditions allow, but the abundance of summer is fading.

Nectar sources become increasingly limited.

Daylight hours continue to shorten.

Night temperatures begin dropping significantly.

The bees recognise these changes long before many beekeepers do.

Their priorities are shifting away from growth and towards conservation.

REALITY CHECK: September is often the last month when beekeepers can easily influence winter survival.

WHAT YOUR BEES ARE DOING

By September, brood rearing is slowing.

Queens may still be laying, but nowhere near the levels seen during spring and early summer. The colony is producing the final generations of winter bees and gradually reducing its overall workload.

Worker bees are still collecting nectar and pollen when available, but colonies are increasingly focused on:



- Protecting food stores
- Raising healthy winter bees
- Conserving energy
- Defending against wasps and robbers
- Preparing for colder weather

Many colonies become noticeably more defensive during this period.

This behaviour is completely normal.

The bees understand that food resources are becoming increasingly valuable.

SEPTEMBER IS ABOUT STORES

If August was about producing healthy winter bees, September is about making sure those bees have enough food.

Every colony should be assessed carefully.

Do not assume a hive is heavy enough because it looked strong earlier in the year.

Do not assume there is sufficient honey simply because the bees remain active.

September is the time to confirm.

Experienced beekeepers frequently lift or "heft" hives throughout autumn to assess food reserves.

Colonies that enter winter with inadequate stores often struggle long before spring arrives.

PRACTICAL RULE: A colony can survive cold weather. It cannot survive running out of food.

AUTUMN FEEDING

Many colonies require supplementary feeding during September.

Natural forage can disappear surprisingly quickly, particularly after prolonged poor weather.

Where feeding is necessary, it should be completed while temperatures remain suitable for bees to process and store syrup effectively.

The objective is not simply to feed bees.

The objective is to build adequate winter reserves.



Every litre of syrup given during September should be viewed as an investment in winter survival.

Leaving feeding too late can create unnecessary problems later in autumn.

VARROA AND WINTER HEALTH

September remains one of the most important months for varroa management.

For many beekeepers, treatments started in August are still ongoing or have recently been completed.

The key question is no longer:

"Have I treated?"

The key question becomes:

"Has the treatment worked?"

Monitoring colonies after treatment is essential.

Healthy winter bees need to emerge in an environment with the lowest practical mite levels possible.

Failure to control varroa successfully often results in colonies entering winter weakened by virus pressure, even when they appear healthy externally.

REALITY CHECK : A colony weakened by varroa in September often pays the price during January and February.

ASSESSING COLONY STRENGTH

September is a month for honest assessment.

Every colony should be evaluated realistically.

Strong colonies generally have:

A good population of bees.

A healthy queen.

Reasonable brood patterns.

Adequate stores.

Low signs of disease or stress.



Weak colonies rarely improve simply because winter is approaching.

In many cases, combining two weak colonies creates one strong colony with a far better chance of survival.

This can feel difficult for new beekeepers, but successful overwintering often depends on making practical decisions rather than emotional ones.

WASPS AND ROBBING

September frequently brings increased pressure from wasps and robbing bees.

Food is becoming scarcer and colonies are defending increasingly valuable stores.

Weak colonies are particularly vulnerable.

Signs of robbing can include:

Fighting at entrances.

Erratic flight patterns.

Bees attempting to enter through cracks and gaps.

Increased aggression around the hive.

Good apiary management helps reduce these risks.

Entrance reduction, careful feeding practices and avoiding exposed honey all become increasingly important.

MOUSE GUARDS AND HIVE SECURITY

As nights become colder, mice begin searching for warm, sheltered locations.

Beehives provide an attractive environment.

A mouse entering a hive during autumn can cause significant disruption and damage.

September is therefore an ideal time to fit mouse guards before temperatures fall further.

It is also worth checking hive roofs, straps, stands and general weather protection.

Small problems are usually easier to fix now than during winter storms.



REDUCING INSPECTIONS

The intensive inspection schedule of spring and summer is no longer necessary.

Swarm control is largely over.

Instead, inspections become more focused and purposeful.

The emphasis shifts towards:

Food reserves.

Colony strength.

Queen status.

Signs of disease.

Winter readiness.

Many successful beekeepers spend more time observing entrances than dismantling colonies during September.

The bees need less interference and more stability.

APIARY HOUSEKEEPING

September is an excellent time to prepare equipment for winter.

Extracted supers should be cleaned and stored.

Spare equipment should be organised and protected from pests.

Old comb can be assessed for replacement next season.

Apiaries benefit from being tidy before weather deteriorates.

Future-you will appreciate the effort when standing in a muddy apiary during January.

RECORD KEEPING

The records created during September often become some of the most valuable notes of the entire year.

These records should include:

Store levels.

Feeding carried out.

Varroa monitoring results.



BeezKnees – September Apiary Master Guide

September apiary master guide for cool, temperate UK climate

www.beezknees.co.uk

Treatment details.

Colony strength assessments.

Queen performance.

Any concerns requiring future attention.

The clearer your records are now, the easier winter management becomes.

SEPTEMBER TAKEAWAY

September is not about producing honey.

It is not about increasing colony numbers.

It is not about expansion.

September is about preparation.

Healthy winter bees, adequate stores, low varroa levels and strong colonies all come together during this month.

Every task completed now makes winter easier.

Every task postponed becomes a potential problem later.

REALITY CHECK : Winter survival is rarely decided in winter. For many colonies, it is decided in September.